Service-Level Objectives and Support Procedures

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Summary. Sets customer support priorities, support hours, first-response and update targets by tier, P1 resolution targets, monthly uptime commitments, service credit rules and refund rules, plus the support case procedure and worked examples for Northstar Systems.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy defines the service-level objectives (SLOs) that Northstar Systems Private Limited commits to for customers of the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect and Nexus Insight, and the procedures Support follows to meet them. It sets out how a customer case is given a priority, what response and update times apply for each support tier (Standard, Premier and Enterprise), the monthly uptime commitments, how service credits are calculated, claimed and approved, and the limited circumstances in which refunds are given.

It applies to all Customer Success, Support and Engineering staff who handle customer cases, and to the Finance Controller when approving large credits. Escalation levels are covered in CS-001, customer messaging in CS-005, and account health in CS-008. Where a customer's signed contract states different terms, the contract prevails, but any deviation from this policy in a contract must be approved by Legal and recorded by the Customer Success Manager (CSM). Contract-related statements here are illustrative; to be verified by Legal before external use.

2. Definitions

- **Case**: a customer request or problem recorded in NorthAssist, the customer support ticketing and portal system.
- **Priority**: P1 Critical, P2 High, P3 Medium or P4 Low, set by Support based on impact.
- **First response**: the first substantive reply from a Support Engineer that acknowledges the case, confirms priority and starts diagnosis. An automatic acknowledgement does not count.
- **Business hours**: 9:00-19:00 IST, Monday to Friday, excluding company holidays.
- **Workaround**: a temporary action that restores the customer's essential function without a permanent fix.
- **Resolution**: the permanent fix, or a workaround accepted by the customer.

- **Monthly uptime**: the percentage of minutes in a calendar month during which the affected service was available, excluding scheduled maintenance.
- **Monthly subscription fee**: the fee for the affected service for the month in which the shortfall occurred.
- **Scheduled maintenance**: planned work announced to customers in advance under section 8.

3. Priority Definitions

Priority	Name	Definition	Examples
P1	Critical	Production is down or data is at risk	All Pipelines failing; suspected data loss
P2	High	A major feature is impaired	A key Connector failing for all runs
P3	Medium	Partial impairment with a workaround	Intermittent Pipeline failure that can be re-run
P4	Low	A question or cosmetic issue	How-to question; small UI defect

The Support Engineer sets the initial priority from the customer's impact statement, not from the customer's tone or the customer's tier. A customer may suggest a different priority, and the Support Lead must review the request and respond in writing within the first-response target for the proposed priority. Priority may be raised or lowered as facts change, and each change must be recorded in NorthAssist with a reason. A priority must never be lowered solely to avoid missing a target.

Example: A customer reports that a report in Nexus Insight shows the wrong colour on a chart. This is P4. The same customer later reports that the nightly data load fails and dashboards are empty before a board meeting. If the dashboards are the only impact and an older report can be used, it is P3; if the data load failure blocks a production Pipeline that feeds the customer's billing, it is P1.

4. Support Hours and Coverage

- **Standard tier**: business hours 9:00-19:00 IST, Monday to Friday, excluding company holidays, for all priorities.
- **Premier and Enterprise tiers**: 24x7 coverage for P1 and P2. P3 and P4 are handled during business hours.
- All tiers receive P3 and P4 support in business hours only.

Outside business hours, a Standard customer may log a case in NorthAssist, and the response clock starts at the next business hour for P1 and at the next business day for lower priorities. Premier and Enterprise customers must use the P1 hotline or the portal flag for P1 and P2 outside business hours so that the on-call Support Engineer is alerted. The on-call arrangements for Engineering are in ENG-005.

5. First-Response Targets

First-response targets depend on tier and priority. Business hours apply to the Standard tier for P1, and for P3 and P4 for all tiers where the target is stated in business hours or business days.

Priority	Standard	Premier	Enterprise
P1 Critical	1 hour (business hours)	30 minutes	15 minutes
P2 High	4 business hours	2 hours	1 hour
P3 Medium	1 business day	4 business hours	2 business hours
P4 Low	2 business days	1 business day	1 business day

Premier and Enterprise P1 and P2 targets run 24x7. The clock starts when the case is created in NorthAssist, or when the customer's call is logged, whichever is earlier. For a P1 raised by phone, the Support Engineer must create the case during the call.

Example: A Premier customer logs a P2 case at 21:10 IST on a Wednesday. The first-response target is 2 hours, running 24x7, so the first response is due by 23:10 IST. For a Standard customer logging the same case at 21:10 IST, the target runs in business hours, so the clock starts on Thursday at 9:00 IST and the first response is due by 13:00 IST (4 business hours).

6. Update Frequency and Resolution Targets

Support must update the customer at the following frequencies until the case is resolved or the customer agrees to a different cadence in writing.

Priority	Standard and Premier	Enterprise
P1	Every 60 minutes	Every 30 minutes
P2	Every 4 hours	Every 2 hours
P3	Every 2 business days	Every 2 business days
P4	Weekly	Weekly

Target workaround or resolution time applies to P1 cases only: Standard 8 hours, Premier 6 hours, Enterprise 4 hours. These are targets for restoring service or providing a workaround, not guarantees of a permanent fix. For P2 to P4 cases, the Support Engineer agrees an expected timeline with the customer after diagnosis and records it in NorthAssist.

Updates must say what has been done, what is being done now and when the customer will hear next, even if there is no change. A message that only says "we are working on it" is not a valid update. If a P1 target is about to be missed, the case owner must warn the Support Lead before the deadline so that escalation under CS-001 is not delayed. The automatic escalation points are 2 hours (Level 2), 4 hours (Level 3) and 8 hours (Level 4).

7. Monthly Uptime Commitments

Northstar commits to the following monthly uptime for the customer's production service, by tier.

Tier	Monthly uptime commitment
Standard	99.5%
Premier	99.9%
Enterprise	99.95%

Uptime is measured per calendar month for the production service the customer has purchased. Minutes of scheduled maintenance, as defined in section 8, do not count against uptime. Downtime caused by the customer's own systems, networks, configuration or by events outside Northstar's

reasonable control is not counted. Uptime is calculated by Operations from NorthWatch monitoring data and published to Customer Success by the fifth business day of the following month.

For reference, a 30-day month has 43,200 minutes. A commitment of 99.5% allows about 216 minutes of downtime, 99.9% about 43 minutes and 99.95% about 21 minutes. These figures are rounded and are given only for understanding.

8. Scheduled Maintenance

Scheduled maintenance is excluded from uptime only if all of the following are true.

- It was announced to customers at least 7 days in advance.
- It does not exceed 4 hours in total in the calendar month.
- It takes place outside the business peak, between 01:00 and 05:00 IST.

Maintenance that does not meet these conditions counts as downtime. Announcements are made on Northstar Status and by email to the customer's registered contacts. The Head of Customer Communications approves the wording under CS-005. Emergency maintenance, such as a security patch for an actively exploited vulnerability, may be performed on shorter notice but counts as downtime unless the customer's contract states otherwise.

Example: Operations announces maintenance on 3 June for 01:30-05:30 IST. This is four hours, which is within the 4-hour limit, and it begins at 01:30, within the window, but it ends after 05:00. The part after 05:00 (30 minutes) is outside the permitted window and counts as downtime, even if the announcement was timely.

9. Service Credits

When monthly uptime is below the commitment for the customer's tier, the customer is eligible for a service credit based on the monthly subscription fee for the affected service.

Monthly uptime achieved	Credit
Below the commitment but at least 99.0%	5% of the monthly subscription fee
Below 99.0% but at least 95.0%	15% of the monthly subscription fee
Below 95.0%	30% of the monthly subscription fee

The credit cap is 30% of the monthly fee. Credits are cumulative with nothing else for the same downtime and cannot exceed the cap.

Rules:

1. The customer must claim in writing, by email to the CSM or through NorthAssist, within 30 days of the end of the month in which the shortfall occurred. A claim after that date may be declined, although the CSM may escalate a late claim to the Director of Customer Success where Northstar was clearly at fault.
2. Credits are applied to the next invoice. They are never paid in cash, and they have no value if the customer terminates, unless the contract says otherwise.
3. The CSM checks the uptime figure with Operations, calculates the credit in INR and records the calculation in NorthAssist.
4. Credits above INR 1,00,000 need Finance Controller approval before they are confirmed to the customer.

5 The credit is calculated on the monthly fee for the affected service only, not on the customer's total spending.

Example: A Premier customer pays INR 6,00,000 per month for the Nexus Platform subscription. In September the measured uptime is 99.7%, below the 99.9% commitment but above 99.0%. The credit is 5% of INR 6,00,000, which is INR 30,000. The CSM calculates it, the customer claims on 4 October, and the credit is applied to the October invoice. No Finance Controller approval is needed because it is below INR 1,00,000.

Example: An Enterprise customer pays INR 12,00,000 per month. In a bad month the uptime is 98.2%, which is below 99.0% but above 95.0%. The credit is 15%, which is INR 1,80,000. This is above INR 1,00,000, so the CSM must obtain Finance Controller approval before confirming it to the customer, and must record the approval in NorthAssist.

10. Refunds

Refunds are given only in the cases below.

- **Termination for uncured material breach by Northstar**: a pro-rata refund of prepaid fees for the period after termination.
- **New Standard-tier subscriptions**: a 14-day money-back window from the start of the subscription.

There is no refund for unused seats in the middle of a term. A customer who wants to reduce seats must do so at renewal, unless the contract says otherwise. Service credits are not refunds. Any refund request must be passed to the CSM and Finance, and the amount must be approved under the Delegation of Authority described in OPS-001 for amounts in the relevant band.

11. Support Case Procedure

1 **Log**: The customer raises a case through the NorthAssist portal, email or phone. Support creates or confirms the case within minutes and checks that the contact is authorised for the customer's tenant.
2 **Triage**: The Support Engineer sets priority using section 3, checks for known incidents on Northstar Status, and requests missing required information (tenant ID, Workspace name, Nexus version, request ID, timestamp with timezone, steps to reproduce, impact statement).
3 **First response**: Sent within the target in section 5. It must confirm the priority, the owner and the time of the next update.
4 **Diagnose and act**: The Support Engineer uses the troubleshooting guide CS-002 and engages Engineering when needed.
5 **Update**: Updates follow section 6.
6 **Escalate**: Under CS-001, automatically or on request.
7 **Resolve**: The Support Engineer confirms the resolution with the customer, records the cause, and sets the case to resolved. The case closes automatically after 5 business days without customer reply, unless a P1 or P2 which are closed only after the customer confirms or the Support Lead approves.
8 **Review**: P1 and P2 cases are reviewed by the Support Lead within 5 business days. Customer satisfaction (CSAT) is requested for every closed case.

12. Measuring and Reporting SLOs

The Head of Support is responsible for monthly reporting on:

- first-response attainment by tier and priority, aiming for at least 95% of cases within target;
- update compliance, measured as the share of open P1 and P2 cases updated on time;
- P1 workaround time against the tier target;
- escalation count by level, from CS-001;
- uptime by tier and credits issued in INR.

Targets for the percentage figures are management goals, not customer commitments. A miss of a first-response target is not a credit event on its own; credits are linked only to monthly uptime. Missed targets are reviewed in the monthly Support operations meeting with the root cause and an action owner. The VP Customer Success receives a summary every month and reviews trends quarterly.

13. Exceptions and Edge Cases

- **Customer delay**: when Support waits for information from the customer, the target clock pauses with a recorded reason. It restarts when the customer replies. Support must chase every business day.
- **Out-of-support versions**: Nexus 4.3 reached the end of support on 2026-06-03. Cases on unsupported versions receive best-effort diagnosis, and the Support Engineer must tell the customer that fixes may require an upgrade. Supported versions are 4.2 LTS until 2027-01-20, 5.0 LTS until 2028-02-10 and 5.1 until 2027-08-18.
- **Multiple customers affected**: when an Engineering incident (SEV1 or SEV2) is declared, cases are linked to the incident and updates may follow the incident cadence, provided that the customer-specific frequency in section 6 is still met.
- **Holidays**: Standard customers have no coverage on company holidays. Premier and Enterprise P1 and P2 coverage continues 24x7 on holidays.
- **Disputed uptime**: if a customer disputes the uptime figure, the Head of Support and Operations must provide the NorthWatch data and review it with the customer within 10 business days.
- **Contract differences**: if a contract promises more than this policy, the CSM must brief Support so that the case is handled accordingly.
- **Free trials and pilots**: unless the contract says otherwise, pilot customers receive Standard-tier P3 and P4 support and no uptime commitment or credit.

14. Related Documents

- CS-001, Customer Escalation Policy.
- CS-007 for knowledge base standards.
- CS-009 for related customer-facing service documents.
- CS-002 for diagnostic steps and CS-005 for communication standards.

15. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2024-11-18	First release of the service-level policy
1.1	2025-07-25	Aligned credit bands, maintenance rules and Enterprise update frequency